

Michael Lennon : "Co-inferencing Organizational Symbiosis"

59:11

okay welcome back from that
brief brief
break we're here with Michael Lenin and
the session is co- inferencing
organizational symbiosis so Michael
thank you for joining take it
away hello yes um I am uh so grateful to
be here I would like to um approach
today's conversation in um in a
conversational style where um I share
what led me to active inference and how
the discovery of the principles of free
energy principle and and active interest
changed how I understood as a
practitioner and and how that has led
both to both personal professional and
and
organizational um shifts in
conversations um one of which will
conclude in an invitation to this
Community to um experiment with an uh an
organizational structure uh designed for
um building both the global n knowledge
comments um as well as um uh building
individual Venture so similar to the way
in which uh for example Linux is open
source uh and then you have Ventures
building off of Linux to do things in
the world that that experimenting with
such a
an organizational model uh for uh the
active inference comments uh is some an
experiment worth taking on so I I I
don't want to let the the final invite
get away but but I'm going to backtrack

and do this very much in a storytelling fashion so um so um I have some slides but I'm not going to uh spend too much time uh well in fact let me just um skip that just to recap what this um

uh what this conversation is about is different ways in which um not just active inference but um science has collided with internal intuition and led to transformational journeys of different kinds and so um and so um I would describe the um you know I I started out as an individual uh as a uh Economist um and um and as a technologist working at um institutions such as the World Bank and IBM and U doing large scale um it implementation projects and um and that work often although there was a lot of um engineering um it was often the human factors that got in the way of success or failure and so um that has been a kind of orienting um how to both be informed by what the the the science and the math provides and uh then build uh how does the biologically based if you will way of sense making um affect or um alter the the the the evolution of of successful project implementation so um just um a little bit about um about where this uh project um prior to coming to active inference um well I say project my journey um led me through was was

um I had a uh I had as I said been trained as a as an economist and um one of the things that economist is a point

of view about what it means to grow the culture to grow the society and um primarily denominated in dollars and using um GDP as a way of um of uh tracking whether or not one was impacting the experience of flourishing and um I came across a uh a chart by um by an economist that showed that GDP had tripled in the last 60 years both in the UK and the us and that well-being had not changed at all and this economist who had been in office in the UK at the time when when he left office was kicked out um he went back to Academia and started looking into what do science show moves the needle of well-being and how do we make this socially more contagious and um and I both U loved the idea but I also was um uh shocked by that information because as someone who was trained in a particular lens a particular perspective what I had been trained to do and how to um cause effect and impact was in fact not moving the needle of well-being and so there was this kind of personal and professional crisis um that arose from this uh from this knowledge and um as I say that that led to this this journey of unlearning in some ways and um and in both personal interpersonal and organizational ways of recalibrating the experience of what does it mean to pay attention to thriving and so um that Journey has been very satisfying um not only do I understand how I need to be to experience uh more

goosebumps in my life uh I understand uh how I need to be to experience connection and belonging and to co-create with others uh a sense of um of purpose and of meaning that um that I had not had previously and it's uh one of the ways I sometimes uh describe this relationship between the subjective uh internal experience and the scientifically objective let's call it was that I might know how to go to the gym and flex uh my arms to get a workout but by understanding Anatomy I could learn um the bicep had a particular placement in the body a particular Arrangement and I still had to do the workout but I could more effectively and skillfully uh do the work that needed to be done of working out and so similarly the study of the science of well-being um and social uh social uh Sciences of of connection of groups and of um and of um how how for example um one of the surprising findings for me uh in in the realm of Happiness was um a finding by an epidemiologist and um basically he um was studying how do emotions spread and um and he in studying this realized that your happiness um uh was not only more heavily infl uh influenced by the people that you're surrounded by but also by the next degree of separation the people to whom they are connected and even the third degree of separation and so that these three um

Degrees of Separation predicted your happiness more than uh the way that I explained I had been explained what happiness was which was that uh it is an inalienable right like life and Liberty the pursuit of happiness and that it's subject to individual traits of my own that if I just do me the best I can then I'm going to be happier and so all of a sudden there's this disorienting um Insight in that it's not about being my best but it's just as important to inter be my best and so it's like well what the heck does that mean what does it what does it look like to to inhabit one's own experience and one's own skin in in a completely different way and and I know a conversation that uh you and I Daniel once had about um about um the impact of active inference you were describing how you might have been driving on the right hand side of the road your whole life and that all of a sudden you um you uh go to a place where everybody drives on the left and so some intuitions still work exactly as as they used to but others are completely counterintuitive and so this developing the capacity to to go against intuition against the The Familiar is um is part of what sometimes these these these new forms of knowledge there's there's knowledge that that adds to what we know and then there's knowledge that changes how we understand and and happiness first did that for me intuitively at the personal experiential level right it

first was like okay I I am playing the
game of my own life uh
inappropriately um how do I how do I
begin to interb my best instead of be my
best and this is where um uh some
subsequent work in working personally
and then with groups and and
organizationally
led to um paying attention to what was
happening in in a different way and uh
so I uh as I say this this um crisis led
to a very fruitful um Learning Journey
and um and
uh excuse me I
um I got distracted um
some of this led to writing different
ways of describing how to do work and so
for example one of the spaces that I've
been working in was in U government
Consulting and in government Consulting
top down um uh uh is often the way to
direct the effectiveness of the
organization um you come up with the
right strategy you figure out all the
components and you then execute on the
plan
and uh and so in a sense uh if there are
two forms of
of uh probabilistic prediction a basian
being one at the heart of of active
inference and another one being fisher
fisher is one that that says it knows
where you need to go and the way that
you relate to to surprises and to
mistakes and errors is you correct back
to what you felt your original plan was
whereas basian probabilism probability
obviously um can have similar results

but also can update instead of reacting
to surprise as something to be fixed it
can sometimes be something to be adapted
to and uh it changes the way that uh
manage you manage um the the uh
emergence of differing information from
what you originally predicted and so so
in the same way that I described that
happiness uh had a disorienting effect
on how to practice it active inference
has a similar um disorienting effect
about how to
co-regulate um how to supervise the um
the evolution of of differences between
what you expect and what you what you
get and um one way in which I I describe
this uh to to folks is it changes your
understanding or changed my
understanding of how cause and effect
works that um you know as as as I
arrived to um to um active inference
there were there were a couple of
intuitions about uh how the world
operated that active inference helped um
evolve the first was that instead of
instead of the world being composed of
objects
um that were fixed and
stable that um that the mathematics of
how to explain things was much more of a
dynamic verb and so to look at the world
as being not nouns but verbs and and and
a way that I describe this for myself
when talking to people about it is that
instead of seeing myself as a self a
noun that I'm a be a being and so um
that pain paying attention to the
continuous verbing and the relating uh

to to to others is is a is a different
um uh a different game and
so um the interesting thing about active
inference was that there was a
mathematics for describing this that
um that related the internal States and
the external States um through
uh mathematics of
information that the way in which um the
the way in which
um uh science

Works um is is is familiar and intuitive
to to to many of us um Let me let me let
me rephrase this in a different way that
you know when I say the inside and the
outside are informationally connected um
that that

um that the outside is all the
information all the stimulus of the
world and that the inside creates a map
of that world and that the mathematics
of creating that map not only um uh
reduce the world and is a mathematically
um efficient way of describing how to
make the how to get the most signal for
for all the information that's being
received but that it also um
it it also um

enables like I was describing earlier
with the understanding of the bicep a
more accurate way of sensing the world
of um orienting to the world and um and
of responding to the
world um I

I should have uh shared my my slides
instead of trying to talk through them
but I'm going to take a a pause and ask
any any questions or shall I proceed

yeah uh I'll ask one question and then
looking forward to slides dsk
wrote there has been a lot of talk
around GDP not being a good enough
metric of national development has your
research informed you on a better metric
if so does it have a working
name so yes and it's a different um
answer than a single metric so the
metric a single metric was one of the
problems and the fact that it was
denominating currency was one of the
problems so one of the things that uh
has shifted um some of the work of uh
the UN of of really a group led by Bill
Bowie and Ralph thurm on um on what are
called contextual
indicators are that um
are that instead of an indicator being
um GDP is both currency and it's um it's
set to a single the denominator and the
nominator of the indicator are both set
in in the same thing so um let me
describe this in a in a different way um
there has been a diversification of what
are the things to pay attention to so
not only um dollars but also subjective
experience of well-being for example
better predicts the outcome of Elections
than does Financial income and so um the
idea that dollars are are predictive
accurately predictive of um of outcomes
has been often relied upon and turns out
to be U maladapted right and so that's
um whether whether you're talking about
biological phenomén whether you're
talking about social phenomena there's a
whole range of extra indicators that are

now seen as um not a single one but but
better visibility into these different
nested levels of of Life the second what
I would call breakthrough type of
indicator Beyond GDP that I was
describing denominator and uh not
numerator is that um most organizational
reporting for example is is um for
example example um Starbucks might say
we are
using 10,000 gallons less of water than
we did last year so we are improving um
our consumption and the way that we are
related to um The Watershed that we
might be related to and and all that um
reporting is if you will individual
Centric and when you Center
your just like as as with happiness you
know where if you're just looking at the
at the individual you're missing an
important part of the picture when when
measuring your relationship to resources
to Commons to um natural Commons and
social Commons um if you if you put your
um uh individual Behavior within the
context of the collective so let's say
Starbucks says uh we used 10,000 gallons
last year out of the total Watershed
then you can begin to draw comparisons
about how everybody is using the
Watershed as a whole and how the
percentage the percentage behavior of of
usage of the water has shifted that can
be compared from one to the next to the
next so if you will you're putting these
indicators in a in a similar language in
a similar uh they're speaking in a in a
similar base than

um than when they are um reported individually and so you know when when looking at at well-being it's it's important not only to to add additional things Beyond money but it's also important that these indicators be um set to the same um denominator or or you wind up not having the visibility that you need and there's a huge cat fight about this because uh there have been a whole series of um of Privileges and a whole series of um um social practices that are grounded in the way in which um uh individual corporations are um are structured and so this this kind of points to a different kind of natural meeme that I wanted to bring up that might be of of Interest so so um we talked about how it with happiness um you know we we're doing it individually and that we're missing the relational um when you look at uh cells that um are part of an organism if they are traumatized uh they become more individualistic they become uh they consume more they reproduce more and they grow into what we call a cancer because their if you will relationality is traumatized and they become more and more selfish and so there's there's both a huge importance of paying attention attention to relationality at the level of the cell at the level of the individual human and some would say at the level of clusters of humans such as organizations and that with cancer part of the um new form of treatment has been to call the cells informationally back

into relation so instead of punitive
burning those cells and killing them
it's to remind them of their relatedness
to restore them from a traumatized State
back into relationship with other cells
and they begin to behave again in better
relation to the body around them and so
that metaphor speaks to the importance
of how do we call each other back into
relation if the language of
individualism is permeating both our
individual Behavior and the language of
Corporations is equally um traumatized
because originally when when uh
corporations were first formed in the
1600s in uh in the Netherlands they were
really people coming together to venture
and do together what they could not do
alone so trading with um the Far East
was was something that no individual uh
Capital uh no individual business owner
could could afford to venture but by
pulling their funds they were able to do
and they were able to become a great
trading power globally this model of
groups behaving as groups so a different
cluster of um of uh of existence groups
um and then behaving
um pro-socially with each other is what
grew the next level of um economic
performance and economic um um
Effectiveness um however over time some
would say that organizations have become
traumatized and have become disconnected
both from the places where they
originated as well as from all the
stakeholders that they were serving and
so for example here in the US when when

the Supreme Court last century two centuries ago now almost decided that financially Financial stakeholders were the foremost important um stakeholders in corporations they distorted the relationality of of Corporations and so it has become a kind of cancer that that has become extractivist both upon the its its employees upon the the the ecosystems in which it inhabits by architecture so there are plenty of people that will tell you in in an organization we want to be more attentive to these um other considerations Beyond Finance but but we don't even have permission because the agreements of the corporation have evolved from mutualism to um to selfishness if you will to more consumerism more productivity more Surplus and those all have a place they're they're they're important but they've become like like the cells in the body that become cancerous they've become overly um overly uh they become individually uh oriented alone and and not sufficiently skillful at at mutualism and so this all comes back to a new basis for equipping organizations to pay attention to how they're interrelating within between and to things beyond their current purview and it is as much of a disorienting and challenging um uh um uh bit of information as I was just

as I was sharing the idea of learning how to be more skillful at happiness was to me personally you know it's like oh I have to pay more attention to you to for for us to be happier or to be the third degree of separation as I was describing earlier means that not only the people to whom I'm directly connected but that really that it's my dumbbar number the dumbbar number being presumably the 150 to the 250 people that you have meaningful relationships in your life the dumbbar cubed so it's beyond your direct sensory observation and it's like how do you co- Haron eyesee across groups how do you sing to use a different kind of language songs in common to which you're Co cooriented and um and these are some of the things that um active inference provides a mathematics for how this works you know that is fascinating of how the synchronization of the individual to the group and the nesting and and how the signaling happens across the nested groups and so it's it's um it's fascinating the mathematics can be daunting but the promise of it and the ability to do these things more skillfully and reliably is just it gives me goosebumps it gives me goosebumps and this is part of um why I'm trying to tell this somewhat ineffectively I would say today in a story Manner and through experience so that people can pull on the intuitions that they have the memories that they have and say I dare to tackle this

uncertainty building upon these intuitions and feelings that I have and Co
experimenting with others forward and so this is at the heart of what
the uh what the original invitation that I mentioned was about was you know that instead of the classic hierarchical um corporation that um that has as part of its founding documents when you when you plant a seed and you use the template that says we are we are organizing according to these rules even if you want to change it's it's like it's a lot harder to change the Constitution than it is some minor policy in a back office in a you know in your in your um you know in some app that you might be uh writing the code for you know and and similarly it's important to to incubate um uh organisms that have the relationality the mutualism and the holistic perspective codified into and the intering codified into how they behave individually intercluster and then in relation to the comments that they might serve and so before I take a turn into the case for um the experiment that I was hoping to invite people to uh do together any any more questions popping up sure I can ask some short questions then slides and invitation okay lightning round okay Arun asked isn't there a cyclic dependency of economic factors and happiness for example High inflation made everyone sad over 2024 so there there is um uh there are um time lag factors uh that impact um uh

when we how the economy operates and how individuals operate and these are not necessarily in sync one of the things that um that uh I found from the um from the science of Happiness was um more effective ways to carry the suffering and so um some have that this change that just happened politically for example um is a bad thing of often when things break open there are whole new Realms of possibility to to be had and so um happiness is not just about having all positive emotions it's about taking well-being is the word actually I should be using is about absorbing all of the signal that the universe is is giving all that's coming in and then optimizing within that and so um the breaking down can also be a breaking open for what there is to to uh become and so that is not to say that there is a lack of struggle or pain or friction one of the great intuitions for me um that that arose from from studying people explaining active inference was um how things emerge and the person explaining it was using water and uh they they were describing still water as being the way in which current conventions of how things got done and how people calculated so if you're if you're in Still Water if you're in a lake and you're trying to get across um the way you Rod your boat or the way you swim is all set by the conditions of the water in um in flowing water um even though those that same water has the same physical properties uh as Still Water it

weighs the same no matter whether it's moving or not um when when the friction of the water over rocks um creates new dynamics that emerge it creates whirlpools right and that those structures um that persist um you know the creation of order out of disorder um allow for the emergence of also other meta patterns that are again described by informational mathematics rather than the physics of the water itself and and this is this is again trying to get it what is so hard to Intuit it it's like oh these the whether whe it's a single Whirlpool coming into existing or whirlpools into whirlpooling into into greater movements that um that these frictions are also creative and so to really um be willing to settle into the into the dis into the what you were calling the cyclical disconnect in a symmetry um as as something that is a signal also that can be driving learning driving better calibration um can be driving um new learning uh because at the heart of all of active inference is a mathematics of continuous learning

um yes I I love that and just blows like water with our previous sessions okay next question and then back into the flow we go social Design Studio wrote so curious about the transition away from from individualistic and mechanical into Collective and organic where is the most levered locality to start well that's a a great question and um here's um a way in which I would

answer this in the in the world of
project

evaluation so there's a point of view um
in the world of systems thinking there's
a certain order of what to um what of
the you know Donella Meadows is well
known for for uh the way in which she
created this categorization of ways to
intervene in a system and um uh in the
world of evaluating um projects and
programs complex projects and program
over time uh there's been some some meta
studies done about what are the things
that best

predict uh that if if the supervision is
done uh attending to certain factors
what are the things that seem to produce
effective and positive results because
we're talking about complexity you could
pick a thousand things but in in this
research they identified three things
and I'll add two the three things that
they said you know when people look at
the following things they they tend to
not only manage what they thought they
were looking for but also what emerges
in other words managing the surprise and
the unexpected more effectively and the
three things were looking at the inter
relationality surprise surprise right
we're talking paying attention to the
interbeing and the interbeing across not
just the individual or whatever whatever
our our individual unit of focus was
originally but but who
are seeing the system more
holistically second um
multiperspectivity um and the way that I

in my the way I uh describe this for my
myself is um I say looking within
looking between and looking beyond
having one or more um disciplines and
perspectives and ways of knowing about
uh those those lenses of of attention on
what is happening um uh if we look to if
we look within we often become a better
compass for our own lives um uh if we um
if we look between we often develop and
harness the intelligence uh that
collectively and the Insight that we
have and when we look Beyond we often
detect uh patterns that are beyond our
Collective purview that might uh um
break open and um enable us to to
transform in in powerful ways so again
to return to that second Point
multiperspectivity um and I suggest with
those three uh lenses which is what I
call the me to we to all you know um and
it's it's kind of the label that I'm
putting on on this invitation I'm going
to bring up later um is um is a is a
good starting point is it enough no but
it's a great starting point and then
thirdly and here's where it gets messy
and is the non-answer to your original
question is um scope
definition um because the moment you
pick what are the boundaries what is my
mark of blanket you know what what what
is the what are the boundaries of the
map that I'm going to use as my lens you
begin to abstract everything else into
what fits in that lens so so if you say
we're going to have this conversation in
English the way that we everything we

describe will be denominated mostly in nouns instead of in verbs and with Concepts that exist in English but don't exist in other languages and so um the attending to what are the boundaries that we will use to focus is is a gigantic mechanism for seeing um how you're holding your attention and so again it's not a fixed answer but it's a way of attending to perception again repeating relationships diversity of perspectives and scope definition uh the other two that I like to add in that um were not part of that research so that research by the way was um a 100 Years of developmental evaluation um you know hundreds of studies and and so it's very robust and you can you can go to the bank that that's a good place to start building your dashboard or not the dashboard your conversations about the dashboard um the other two that I would add and and these in part come from active inference and from other systemic view places and Views is looking at patterns how are we you know what are we clustering and looking at flows you know um what what are the core flows are we looking at energy if we're looking at biological systems are we looking at the water flows you know life organizes around water um so do do we understand what are the core flows of information of energy whatever uh in the system that we are observing that that that gives us a a key insight into the way in which

causality

unfolds um and causality uh organizes
itself around and that it's not the
mechanistic you know geometry that we we
may have intuited in uh for for the
longest time but that by looking at
Source by looking at flow we we develop
a better compass for for the
world thank you it's it's awesome and
the live chat is super lit you'll see it
after

um in the last 20 minutes do you want to
share your slides and open the
invitation

letter yes so uh let me um switch here
to

share um

share are you seeing my screen okay uh
me so

um the

invitation uh was

um was to test a new way of organizing
and a fair share Commons is a kind of um
a mutualistic co-op that um first
originated in the UK and has been
endorsed by the

financial I I I should have read it down
here because I can't remember like the
finance trust accounting Board of of the
UK it's spread through many countries of
the Commonwealth of the last uh 15 20
years and it's primarily an adapted form
of organizational structure that is
intended to both cultivate the practice
of mutualism within the group so it's
kind of like a co-op um in that
everybody has power uh to to participate
it's

self-governing um and that it attends to the relationality of the founders the workers and uh and external whether they're investors or they they self-organize it's really uh there is a a pattern language about forming co-ops and one can use that pattern language to to um to to form these Commons and that these whether they are to create Ventures um or to create um full businesses that the pattern language is useful for that effect um and so as I described earlier a kindelin um you know it's it's intended to grow the commons but also to support the application of those Commons and build the organizational traits uh for successful Ventures and what I am uh hoping to find allies uh around um oops let me um so it um the these are again suggested and there are many ways to to go about it but um you know there there's certain core agreements that differ from if you will the extractivism and the foundation is uh relationality um which drives mutualism symbiosis um and uh the the invitation um is to um is to constitute one in service of the active inference uh Community for growing both the commons and the capacity to um to prototype and devel both the the experience of mutualism but also projects and that uh there' be two starting experiments um the first around prototyping uh agents for accelerating access to money so often um folks incubating a new project are looking to

find funding for that project um find uh
funding for what that project might
serve and often there are people willing
to fund those projects and the idea of
wrri up what are the sources of
different funding what are the sources
of what what are the needs that they
have that they're looking to fund how do
I um discover and engage that um funding
is an important agent that can be used
in common after common after common and
so possibly developing a um an agent or
uh there are plenty of methods but but
agen toying if you will uh that
component as one of the key flows you
know that in business the flow of money
is is an important element to to an
activate and and that the second is
about um finding um resources of a
different kind competence and
complimentarity and um what are the what
are the components often for example a u
uh the active inference Community has a
wide diversity of competencies um the
but but it is highly highly Tech
technical and so to engage with people
who who um have complimentary SK skills
um uh and and um and to support the
accelerated discovery of allies not only
based on competencies but also on um uh
other holistic considerations is um is
the attending to the flow of mutualism
um and so those those three um actions
is kind of a starting point is um is
something that I would like to um I'm
I'm already in action on the uh with
with other groups um and a variety of
groups on the constituting the legal

structure of a of a fair sharing
comment um and I would like to enroll
um the active entrance Community to
become an ally with with kind of other
competencies and other types of
mutualistic eco-minded socially minded
groups to grow grow um the capacity for
mutualism and it's early stage I
literally um this this is germinating
you could say and really would like to
um would like to find allies who who
knowing that we don't have all the
answers but that we're willing to grow
not just the methods but the relational
soil um is um is what this is really
about so um yeah awesome Stu
there awesome exciting I can ask some
questions from live chat and we can
explore just a little bit of
a shall I leave this on the screen or
keep going sure you can leave it up I'll
ask there's a lot of great comments I'll
just start with the direct question so
people can add more in this last 15
minutes okay social Design Studio wrote
does the commons use emergent hierarchy
so as to accommodate contextual
expertise and thus relational power
so um great question and um there
are several definitions of Commons um
but I'm going to go with elen orstrom
she won the Nobel Prize for it and um
and she she basically defined it as it's
whatever Mark of blanket people choose
and then self-organize around so so um
there are many variations and um and in
order she she identified eight
principles for common to not just be a

nice idea but to be able to persist sustainably right um just to do a little sidebar she she was trying to make a business the reason she won the Nobel Prize is because in the profession um everybody was explaining most of the economy's activities as either being driven through hierarchies or through marketplaces the Dynamics of those two Collective groups and she said there's a Third Kind of group a common and it has the following properties and um the socially mutualistic uh side of the world was just in love with her and this is why she won the Nobel Prize because she developed not only a body of Science and a series of eight principles that predictably describe those that succeed these eight include you know a sense of a boundaries that they have in common and whether they decide to self-organize around a fishery whether they decide to organize around um a data comment around uh a knowledge comment that is up for the group to to decide and then um the the way in which they co-regulate um she did there there were many variations but but basically there was a um there had to be agreements on where to place shared attention and as people diverged from the Norms that there were ways to call them back into relationship ship and to have escalating um consequences if people deviated um now all of that sounds lovely but um but that was not enough either there had to be the ability to enforce one's boundaries not only internally but

externally and so I'll give you an example um I I uh have some First Nation friends with whom I've been meeting every Friday for years to work on decolonizing our minds and they have a point of view about a piece of land that um that is their Garden of Eden and sacred and how it should be used or not be used and they use all these principles but they cannot enforce their agreements on other people and so they really what they have is a wish list I mean I know that's kind of rude and they'll be very pissed to hear me say this but without the capacity to enforce your your boundaries you um you don't have a Commons and so um this idea of uh how enforcement happens and whether that is done in a hierarchical manner or whether that's done by self-organizing you know like when when uh in Valencia recently there was a a a gigantic flash flood you know the government um did a very poor job for the first week and the response was is done by self-organizing ant behavior of neighbors helping neighbors coming in doing whatever they and that happens in crisis after crisis after crisis and um and so there is a a capacity to self-organize if you will and get things done um often what a government structure can do is help prioritize bring order to the what are the most pressing needs how to discern what will make the biggest difference collectively and so there is a value to having a coordinating role but um but uh you know

how that emerges or evolves or unfolds
is um can either be by by cultural
precedent of what the rules are or it
can emerge through and from the group so
um so that's my long comment about
Commons and and commoning and how to be
in relationship to the common awesome I
I'll read a comment from Scott even
before you mentioned asrom Scott had
written Commons Elanor Ostrom is a
co-management regime framing nicely
consistent with active inference in
human organizational contexts C Scott
Shackleford at all at you of Indiana for
Awesomes Commons programs Commons
analyses have historically been focused
on quote asset based Commons this nicely
anticipates common co-management Beyond
Asset Management I.E risk management
skills coordination
Etc yep I I should have made the point
that um one of the things that Commons
do that uh that the marketplaces and the
institutions have not been able to do is
for example it is financially rational
to fish to Extinction to deplete the
forest because the price just keeps on
going up so so so um the logic of
markets is insufficient for for
sustainability and this is why
organizations that don't have a logic of
of of that friction of of um of
considering other factors other than
profit maximization will
inevitably um deplete the resource um
and so what she created with this um
case for Commons was that there were
sustainable organizations and that these

existed both in indigenous you know in
in original people cultures they exist
uh throughout developed economies they
exist in a variety of places and are
unrecognized and what what you're
hearing this in this invitation is like
let's let's let's choose commoning even
though it's unfamiliar even though it's
different it's actually much more
widespread than we ever have experience
you know it's it's like believing that
there might be something other than
McDonald's you see McDonald's everywhere
so you think I have to eat burgers but
there are other ways to eat than
McDonald's and not trying to pick a
fight with uh fast food
but how are we going to carry this
forward into 2025 and
Beyond yes so um so the invitation to
join um a conversation is is the
beginning one one of the Allies is um
that is both co-incubating other Commons
and that I wanted to use for if there's
energy here is um a a group called uh
evolue 6 uh based in Germany and and uh
South Africa and UK uh it's a small firm
dedicated to incubating uh and helping
Commons type organizations grow um it's
kind of the we uh um and and so uh
trying to both invite the interested to
begin join the conversation sharpen uh a
vision and an understanding of what it
is that we think we can be in action on
uh what is it that how that active
inference can be applied to particular
problems the search for funding there
might be a better way I had to I had to

scramble to get something plausible but
if as we have conversations we might
very well identify much more um
important points of intervention with
the question that somebody body else was
asking earlier we might decide that
there are certain flows and certain
dynamics that are in fact a great a
better starting point than what I
imagine right now but uh the invitation
is come let's convene and do this in a
systematic way and both be transformed
individually interpersonally and ripple
out into the
world awesome okay few more questions
while we're still here
Frasier wrote I'm not sure what this
language of trauma means I'd like to
hear this
elaborated yes excellent sorry um I
forgot to explain that so um uh lately
in Psychology and in organizational
psychology uh there has become a
modified use of the word trauma and um
and what it refers to is the equivalent
of memory in in computation
so you can have a traumatic event and be
traumatized by it and then the trauma as
as I'm using it is the memory the scar
that's left either in you or the um if
it's it's a if it's a collective trauma
that has a different um property I'll
describe it in a moment but but when I
say it's the memory the scar is what
remains in you and how you carry that
whether you heal fully or whether it
becomes a a debilitating d Dynamic is is
when the word trauma can be used to

describe it Collective trauma is um and this is an important distinction because sometimes the same language can create confusion

um uh when I'm acting as an individual cognitive system I am all the trauma happens within my body so I feel something I fix something or I have a story about something happening to me all of that is personal trauma if I'm part of a hive the the um hiving is happening in the signals that we are sending back and forth to each other and so um the uh the this the the language of how we signal and the meaning of what that means is what can become traumatized and let me give you a simple little

example uh and and those are called trauma agreements ways in which you agree to carry the the significance the pain the feeling about the situation that you're looking at so so my father took me fishing when I was 8 years old for the first time and we caught a fish with fish and Hook and the fish was flapping and resisting you know and I was kind of shocked I'm like oh my God that fish is suffering my father's like no no no no no you just grab you know whack them on the head knock them out and they don't feel pain and in that moment I entered into a trauma agreement a different understanding of how to be with what I was observing and as a group we would talk about the our reality assuming that shared trauma agreement that shared way of of

understanding that same kind of dynamic
whether it is how what it means to be a
certain gender what it means to be an
organization that is um beneficial to
the world is it because it makes a
profit is it because it makes a
contribution there's a whole series of
assumed agreements that that it's like
oh we need to surface them that they're
not the truth they are an agreement into
which we stepped and we're now willing
to re-evaluate and this is both the the
the gateway to
disorientation but also transformative
adaptation um because it changes what
has been uh a habitual way when when
when I started considering that maybe
animals are still an omnivore but when I
started considering um that maybe
animals had feelings I had to start
thinking differently about what had been
my AR eating patterns and so this is a
language for
surfacing um anti- symbiotic ways of
being that we are now developing a
pattern and a way of recognizing them
and renegotiating
them awesome great answer last
question musicm minded wrote how does
Michael see the future of businesses or
more simply do you have Exemplar
businesses that are commons type in your
view yes there's a whole range of
Commons businesses and and and so even
though we're talking here about
incubating a new one in a sense um I I
believe that the the important work is
about what I was describing about

treating cancer calling back into
relation and so um some of us and this
you know if there's interest in this
I've been working with with global
standard setting groups about how to
measure monitor well-being and then how
to so there's the sensing it and then
there's the what do I how do we digest
it you and this was another benef
another you know benefit from from
active inference was the way of framing
the cognitive process not just think but
sensing integrating predicting
responding adapting and and really
helping organizations think about in
that cognitive flow in that Collective
cognitive flow how to recalibrate them
their their attention so that they see
more of the world with with a denominate
a planetary denominator rather than an
organizational denominator and how do
they then more skillfully interrelate
with the different factors in which
they're they're they're engaging perfect
thank you Michael great presentation a
lot of people appreciated it in the chat
so see you next time thank you thank
you
e for